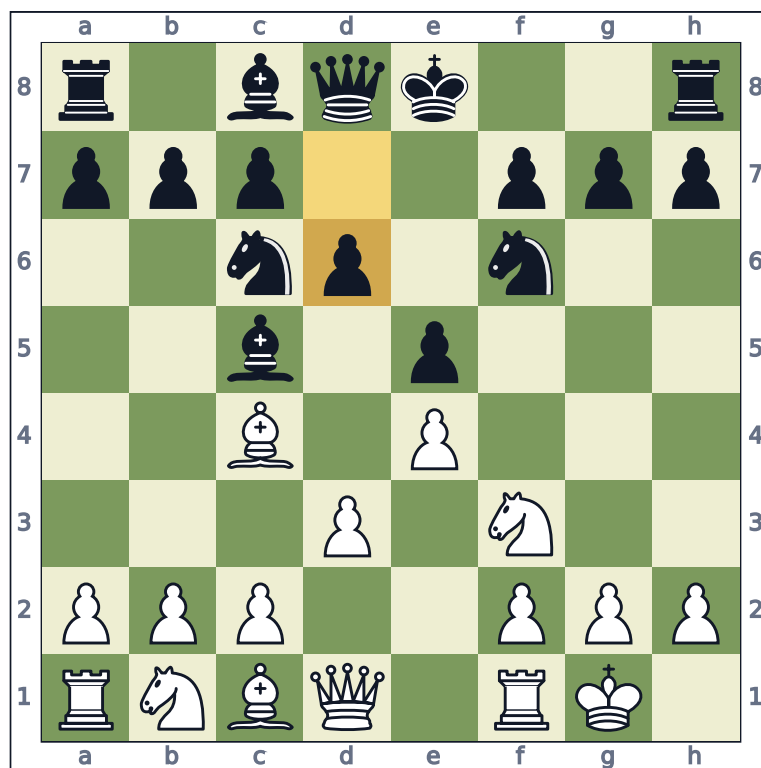


DEFENSE AND PROPHYLAXIS

Ask What the Opponent Wants

Before executing your own plan, identify the opponent's best improvement and consider preventing it cheaply.



Illustrative position after ... d3 Bc5 O-O d6

WHY THIS PRINCIPLE EXISTS

Prophylaxis reduces the opponent's strongest options while preserving your plan. It is efficient control of future possibilities.

THE MECHANISM

Why it works

This principle is not magic and it is not a commandment. It is a compressed prediction about threat reduction. The useful question is: what changes in the position when the principle is followed?

DIRECT CAUSAL MECHANISM

Prophylaxis reduces the opponent's strongest options while preserving your plan. It is efficient control of future possibilities.

BOARD GEOMETRY

Good defense changes the attacker's access, removes key units, or gives the king and pieces new squares.

OPTION QUALITY

Active defense increases the opponent's obligations instead of allowing unlimited reinforcement.

TIME AND TEMPO

The cheapest accurate prevention preserves resources for counterplay and avoids permanent concessions.

WHAT IT PREVENTS

It prevents a recurring class of errors by making a hidden cost visible before the move is played. The principle is valuable because that error pattern appears across many different openings and positions.

RECOGNITION

When to apply it

A principle becomes practical only when you can recognize its trigger. Use the signs below as evidence, then verify the exact position.

- Signal 1: Quiet position.
- Signal 2: opponent has a clear break or piece route.
- Signal 3: one useful move can hinder it..

FOUR-STEP APPLICATION PROTOCOL

1. Notice the trigger without choosing a move yet. 2. Generate at least two candidates, including one that follows the principle. 3. Calculate the opponent's strongest forcing reply. 4. Compare the resulting positions and apply the rule only if the concrete result supports it.

CONVERT IT INTO A BOARD QUESTION

Ask: 'Does this position give me a reason to use the following rule - Before executing your own plan, identify the opponent's best improvement and consider preventing it cheaply.' Then ask the balancing question: 'What tactical or strategic detail could make this position an exception?'

EXCEPTIONS AND CONFLICTS

Where the slogan breaks

Chess strength comes partly from knowing when two good principles conflict. The better player does not repeat the louder slogan; they rank the actual consequences.

IMPORTANT LIMITATION

Do not spend tempi stopping harmless plans. Prevention should be cheaper than the danger prevented.

DECISION HIERARCHY

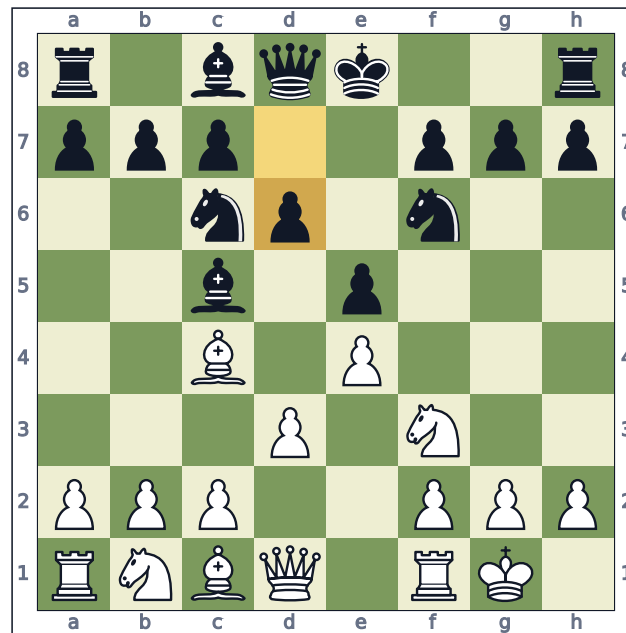
- 1. Legal and tactical survival: checks, forced mate, and immediate material loss.
- 2. King safety and forcing initiative: whose threats arrive first?
- 3. Material and conversion: what durable gain remains when activity fades?
- 4. Piece activity, structure, space, and long-term plans.
- 5. The general principle as a tiebreaker between otherwise sound choices.

RED-FLAG TEST

Before following the rule, look for one changed defender, an exposed king, an intermediate move, a pawn break, or a tactical capture. If any exists, calculate it first. A principle explains typical positions; the board decides this position.

WORKED THINKING MODEL

How a strong player uses it



Illustrative position after ... d3 Bc5 O-O d6

1. Read the position

Start with threat reduction: identify the feature that will remain important after one move.

2. Find the trigger

Look for these signs: Quiet position; opponent has a clear break or piece route; one useful move can hinder it.

3. Produce candidates

Include one forcing move, one move guided by the principle, and one move that prevents the opponent's best idea.

4. Verify

Calculate checks, captures, and threats for the opponent. Try to refute your preferred candidate.

5. Evaluate

Use the mechanism as the explanation, not the proof: Prophylaxis reduces the opponent's strongest options while preserving your plan. It is efficient control of future possibilities.

Note: the board is an illustration for the thinking process, not a claim that one move is forced. Set it up and compare multiple legal candidates.

TRAINING AND RETENTION

Make it automatic

PRIMARY DRILL

At ten master-game positions, predict the opponent's plan and choose one move that hinders it without weakening your side.

SELF-TEST

- Explain the principle without using its title.
- Name two position signals that make it relevant.
- Give one reason the principle works.
- State the exception that most often causes misuse.
- Describe the calculation check required before applying it.
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ANSWER RUBRIC

A strong answer connects the rule - Before executing your own plan, identify the opponent's best improvement and consider preventing it cheaply. - to its mechanism, names a trigger from a real position, and explains this limitation: Do not spend tempi stopping harmless plans. Prevention should be cheaper than the danger prevented.

SPACED PRACTICE LOOP

Review today, then after 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. On each review, retrieve the idea before opening the PDF. Retire it only when you can recognize the trigger in a fresh position and explain an exception.